



Guidon flag

This flag belonged to the 1st Vermont Volunteer Cavalry Regiment, formed to fight for the Union in November 1861. The regiment sustained heavy losses in an ill-considered charge at the Battle of Gettysburg.

Roles of the cavalry

The Confederates were the first to create cavalry units that operated independently, while the Union initially tended to distribute horsemen among infantry formations, where they performed mundane duties as scouts, camp pickets, and guards for railroads. Jeb Stuart's spectacular ride around the Union army during the Peninsula Campaign in June 1862 pointed the way to the use of cavalry for reconnaissance and raids into enemy-held territory.

Few efforts were made to introduce the traditional European-style cavalry charge against infantry and artillery; the firepower present on the field would have made this move effectively suicidal.